

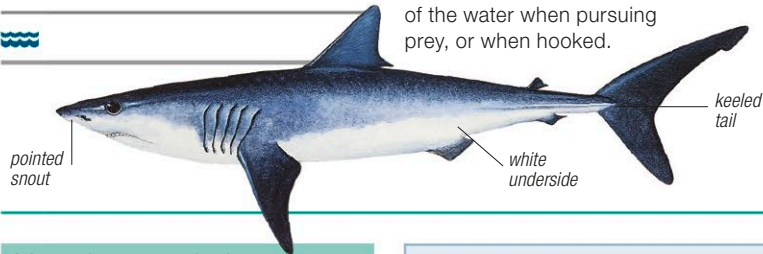
Isurus oxyrinchus

Shortfin mako



Length Up to 13 ft (4 m)
Weight 1,260 lb (570 kg) or more
Breeding Viviparous
Status Vulnerable

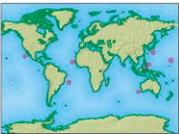
Location Tropical waters worldwide



Also called the blue pointer, mackerel shark, or snapper shark, this is possibly the world's fastest shark. The tail is adapted for speed, with well-defined keels on either side of the base—a common feature in fast-swimming fishes. This shark has large, unserrated, daggerlike teeth that enable it to stab and grip slippery, fast-moving prey such as mackerel, tuna, bonito, and squids. It can jump several times its length out of the water when pursuing prey, or when hooked.

Megachasma pelagios

Megamouth shark



Length Up to 18 ft (5.5 m)
Weight Up to 1,740 lb (790 kg)
Breeding Unconfirmed
Status Data deficient

Location W. and E. Atlantic, S. Indian Ocean, W. and E. Pacific

The megamouth is one of the world's least-known large sharks. It was discovered in 1976 when one specimen became trapped by a ship's underwater equipment off the Hawaiian islands. Around 60 specimens have been seen since. This shark is characterized by an extraordinarily large mouth, which facilitates filter feeding. One of only 3 plankton-eating sharks, the megamouth shark is believed to follow the movement of plankton, rising from deep water to the surface at night and returning to the depths during the day. Its great size means it



Distinctive coloring in and around this shark's huge mouth may be aids to feeding. A luminescent stripe on the margin of the upper jaw and a silvery roof to the mouth—visible as the shark swims along with jaws open—may serve to attract prey.

has few enemies, sperm whales (see p.260) being one of the few predators big enough to tackle this huge fish. However, the megamouth is harmless to humans.



COLOR CONTRASTS

The megamouth's back is uniformly gray to blue-black in color, while the underside of the body is whitish. A white stripe runs along the margin of the upper jaw.

Alopias vulpinus

Thresher shark



Length Up to 18 ft (5.5 m)
Weight 990 lb (450 kg) or more
Breeding Viviparous
Status Vulnerable

Location Temperate and tropical waters worldwide



The thresher shark is uniquely shaped, the upper lobe of its tail fin being almost as long as the

rest of the body. The shark uses this extended lobe to herd fishes together into tight schools, and then stuns them with powerful swipes of the tail. A number of threshers may cooperatively encircle schools of fishes such as herring and small tuna, corraling them with their tails before the final attack. The thresher has also been known to use the tail as a means of defense against humans. Large individuals boated by fishermen may slap furiously with their tails. It is likely that this

Cetorhinus maximus

Basking shark



Length 33 ft (10 m), max 49 ft (15 m)
Weight 6½ tons (6 tonnes) or more
Breeding Viviparous
Status Vulnerable

Location Cool to warm temperate waters worldwide



The basking shark is the world's second largest fish, after the whale shark (see p.477), and like it, is a harmless, migratory plankton-feeder. It often feeds at or near the surface, its huge first dorsal fin and tail fin projecting above the surface. Although primarily solitary, groups of up to 100 may gather to feed in areas where plankton blooms are dense.



PLANKTON TRAPPER



To feed, this filter-feeder must move continuously through the ocean with its mouth agape, a technique known as ram-feeding. As the water is expelled through the enlarged gill slits, mucus-laden gill rakers trap the plankton—which the shark quickly swallows.

WATER OUTLETS

This species has very large gill slits that nearly encircle its head. The gill slits are important for breathing and feeding.

Pseudocarcharias kamoharai

Crocodile shark



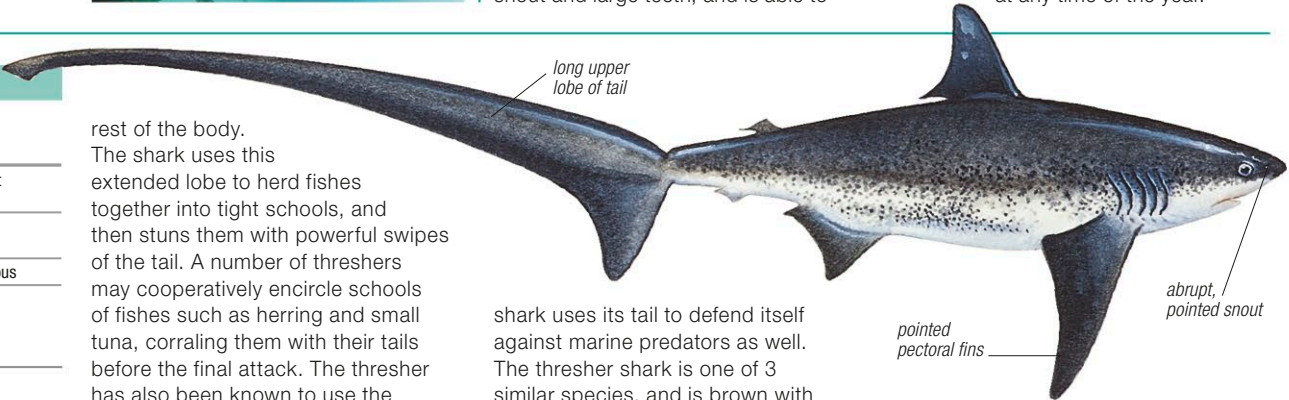
Length 3½ ft (1.1 m) or more
Weight Not recorded
Breeding Viviparous
Status Near threatened

Location Open tropical waters worldwide



This small, cylindrical shark is an oceanic species. It has a pronounced snout and large teeth, and is able to

extend its jaws unusually far forward to snatch at prey, such as medium-sized bony fishes, squids, or shrimps. The crocodile shark is thought to migrate vertically, following its prey toward the surface at night and then sinking again at dawn, its large eyes enabling it to see in dimly lit conditions. Like the sand tiger shark, this species may be an intra-uterine cannibal, with embryos eating each other before the survivors are born. However, this is not known for certain, though they do eat other eggs and only 2 pups are produced from each uterus. Pups are about 16 in (40 cm) long at birth and may be born at any time of the year.



shark uses its tail to defend itself against marine predators as well. The thresher shark is one of 3 similar species, and is brown with a white underside. It is generally confined to deeper waters, but the young and some adults may be found in shallower regions around

coasts. It may, at times, congregate in schools made up entirely of either males or females.